Endangered Species: Case 47401

By Crystal Wilkinson

SPEAKER: All black women got this thrumming inside us, but don't nobody notice. That thrum just sits in our bellies and then one day it comes on so strong that we can't stop it even if we want to. And that's when your abusive husband might get shot. That's when she might quit that stupid job with the manager who says she can't wear dreadlocks. That's when she be in the corner curled up crying her eyes out over somebody black she don't even know that got killed somewhere *(beat)* again. You might see her on the front lines of a protest—loud and regal and effective. What you don't realize is that this thrum been with us always.

INTRODUCTION

Living at the intersection of racism and sexism is far from easy. We are discriminated against for being Black and for being women, existing in both identities at all times. The story of Black women at work and in life is one of resilience. Despite the challenges and barriers in our way, we have accomplished so much and continue to make amazing strides. But it's time to acknowledge it is (insert year) and

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systemic racism is not a thing of the past. It is up close and personal in the present.

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SPEAKER: I was cooking breakfast that morning in my new kitchen. Out the window was six stray cats preening and stretching in the back yard. A gray one was perched on the patio chair, fat and round, looking proud of itself. The cats came to the backyard nearly every day to make themselves known. They'd been there since we moved in two months [ago].

Later that morning, Little V played on the carpet in the living room while I slung cardboard boxes into a corner of the garage and scattered my prized possessions around me in a circle on the kitchen floor. I was just standing there looking at all my heirlooms when I saw a white woman traipsing up our sidewalk, looking like an after school special with that blonde hair curled around her chin. Green sweater with bright red apples, plaid culottes and white stockings. The doorbell rang just as I was wondering if she had the right address. *(Speaker opens the door slightly, cautiously)*

WHITE WOMAN: Are you the lady of the house?

SPEAKER: I am. *(holding the door open just a little)*

WHITE WOMAN: Can we count on you? *(shoving a clipboard through the crack in the door)*

SPEAKER: A man across the street was sweeping his sidewalk. A woman was ushering a girl into a waiting car. An old woman was sitting on a porch in a rocking chair holding a dog. They were all watching. They were all white people. I didn't say nothing, but the thrum was shifting. I took the petition, thanked the woman and shut my door. *(reading the petition)* *(picks up Little V and speaks to him)* What kind of people write a petition to kill cats? Little V looked up at me just like he knew what I was talking about. My sweet, sweet boy.

If them cats had been house cats they would have been something else. Magnificent. The black one lounging on the arms of a couch, a man rubbing on its head, or a girl cradling the yellow one, like a doll while she watched some cartoons. But they were feral, at least that's what that white woman had called them, but I didn't see too much wild about them.

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After that, I went out into the garage for more boxes. That's when I saw a mouse. A different kind of woman would have screamed bloody murder, but I didn't. I knew if I could have gotten close, I could have crushed him with one stomp from my shoe. But that mouse, just like them cats, just like me, wasn't bothering nobody so I left him alone.

It wasn't but a few seconds later, that the doorbell rang again. Here come this white woman with her cat killing petition at my door a second time. Sometimes I just sit back and try to imagine a whole room of white people sitting around in a meeting talking about killing cats. Is that what y'all doing when so many black people are on cooling boards all over this country?

WHITE WOMAN: *(opening the door and letting herself in)* Lady of the house?

SPEAKER: *(low and slow)* How you just come up in somebody's house, lady? *(to audience)* I knew this wasn't going to turn out right. I knew it from that moment.

WHITE WOMAN: We need 50 more signatures. Have you had time to consider our materials?

SPEAKER: *(obviously perturbed)* I **don't** have time. *(to audience)* And as I was trying to close my door she stuck her foot right in my front door. Yes. Can you believe it?

WHITE WOMAN: How long have you lived here?

SPEAKER: And had the nerve to raise her pen up above her clipboard like this, like she was about to write down whatever I said. "What?" That's what I said. "What?!" Just like that.

WHITE WOMAN: Do you have a copy of a mortgage or lease that I could see?

SPEAKER: I leaned my face toward hers and I'm not lying when I tell you that I wanted the tip of my nose to touch the tip of hers to make sure I heard her right. "What did you say? Do I have what?" *(to audience)* She repeated herself then got a little scared look on her face, before she stepped back and removed her foot. I slammed the door closed, but before I could lock it the woman grabbed the door knob and turned it. With Little V in my arms I was losing this game of tug of war. And let me be clear -- my thrumming was there constantly. She yanked the door open wider and stepped one foot back in. Then come

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this wooshing feeling just beneath my heart. Woosh, woosh.

Now I'm telling you, it was never my intention to lay hands on that funny looking white woman but when she wouldn't remove her foot from my door, I pushed her out as hard as I could. Yes, I did that. I sure did. I pushed her out of ***my*** door. She tumbled to the sidewalk. Her pen went one way and her clipboard went another. but she wasn't dead. And you and I know she ain't dead now. I ain't killed nobody. Right? I closed my door and locked it. Ain't that what people do all over the world? Close their door, lock it, and think they're safe?

WHITE WOMAN: *(banging on the door and yelling)* We'll see about this!

SPEAKER: And then suddenly it was quiet again. *(beat)* Little V played peek-a-boo with me, while I worked in the kitchen, his curly head bobbing back and forth from view. A little while after that is when the police showed up. *(she turns and opens the door)*

OFFICER: Ma'am, we've had a report of a situation here.

SPEAKER: The officer was standing at my front door with his hand on his gun. Can you imagine somebody at your front door with a gun when you ain't been in no situation with no police your whole damn life?

OFFICER: May I ask what you are doing in this house, ma'am? We are going to need you to step out here to the sidewalk.

SPEAKER: *(shocked and stammer for words)* What? . . . I don't understand . . . I – I - live here.

OFFICER: Well, some of the folks around here said that they don't think you live here. Do you have any proof? And they saw you assault a woman here, not too long ago. We are looking for the victim. *(more forcefully)* Step out of the house, please.

SPEAKER: The victim?! I live here! *(to audience)* If there had been room for laughter, I sure would have laughed but I stayed quiet. I bounced Little V on my hip and moved him to the other side and my brain was fogged up. But mostly it was my legs that wouldn't act right or move fast enough.

OFFICER: Was there a woman here. A white woman?

SPEAKER: *(dazed)* Yes. Blonde. Talking about killing cats.

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OFFICER: Tell us what happened.

SPEAKER: I started at the beginning, but by then my thrum was threatening to leave my body -- growing and pulsing. I talked about history, my mama. I told them about the birth of my children. I told them about that boy in the park who had been shot because he was holding a toy gun up in Cleveland. I told them about that famous singer who had raped all them young black girls and nobody had done nothing in Chicago. I told them about the woman who had died in the jail in Texas. "You know good and well that woman didn't kill herself," I said.

I told them about the three-year-old Minnesota girl who watched her mother's boyfriend get shot to death by police. "This is why black people don't trust white people or the police," I said. When I got to the part of about the humming thing that lived inside the wombs of black women, the officers looked at each other. One looked surprised. The other one had a smirk on his face like that white boy from Covington had when he was talking to that Native American elder.

"Covington, Kentucky," I said. I talked about Covington. I talked about Kentucky. I'm from Kentucky, too. Did you know that? I talked and talked but when I stopped to catch my breath the officer said

OFFICER: Ma'am, we're going to have to ask you to put the baby down.

SPEAKER: He talked to me like I was a dog and not a woman. *(beat)* I know you think I'm crazy but I'm not. I didn't say nothing else, but I wasn't about to put Little V down. I'd hold him till his daddy and his sister came home if I had to.

I'd hold him until the next time I saw my mama.

I'd hold him until black people stopped dying in the streets. And that's when I heard the thrum louder than I'd ever heard it before. I could feel it spreading through my entire body and then it left my body and floated like a summer storm above our heads, above the neighborhood, above the entire country. And one cop had his hand on his gun and the other one kept saying, "Ma'am I'm going to need you to put that boy down right now." But I didn't. I wasn't going to ever let go of my baby. Not until all my people were free.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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